



Samsung SyncMaster 997DF (19-inch)

The flicker is more prominent when the screen is bright, because bright pixels do not hold their brightness levels for long; if the next refresh is going to take longer, it will result in flicker. It is therefore recommended to keep the refresh rate at 75 Hz or above, if your monitor and resolution can support it.

Reflection when the screen is dark is another problem. This can hamper clear vision of what is on the screen. Most vendors claim to have anti-glare coating on the glass, but this only works when your screen is not dark.

In both the 17-inch and 19-inch categories, the monitors all offered good screen uniformity and flicker-free viewing at 75 Hz, the only exception being the Samsung 793DF, which had a darker shade in the lower left corner. Overall, the dark screen test returned results similar to those in the screen regulation test, with all monitors in both categories suffering. There was not even a single monitor that could return a pure dark screen with no reflection.

In the CRT Shadow Mask test, four bright blocks are at the corners of the screen, and stay bright for 30 seconds. They then disappear. We looked for any remnants, or ghost images, of the bright blocks. As it turned out,

none of the monitors had traces of ghost images.

This test was a lot more useful a decade ago, when the phosphors, if kept glowing for extended periods of time, would keep a bright spot for some time afterward. This is the reason screensavers were developed and used. These days, new monitor technology has done away with the need for screensavers, though we still use them for ornamental and aesthetic purposes.

Cost of Ownership

Prices of everything except CRT monitors seem to be falling. For example, the Microtek 43f1 cost Rs 5,700 last year, and costs the same even now.

In fact, certain repeat models have gotten more expensive—the NEC MultiSync FE791SB cost Rs 16,500 last year, whereas it is currently priced at Rs 17,000. The cheapest 17-inch monitor available right now is the Acer AC713, at Rs 5,495.

In the 19-inch

category, the **Samsung SyncMaster 957MB (19-inch)** Philips 109 B6 was the costliest model at Rs 20,000, followed by the NEC MultiSync, an aperture-grille-based monitor available for Rs 19,000. The cheapest was the HCL HCM985RFM, at Rs 13,100.

Summing It Up

The notable monitors in this test were Benq V773 and NEC MultiSync FE791SB, which gave the highest pure performance scores, but couldn't make it to the top due to low features scores or a higher price tag. The NEC merits special mention as it was the only aperture-grille-based monitor capable of a high resolution of 1,600 x 1,200 at 70 Hz, which makes it the best buy for graphics professionals.



The Acer AF715 wins the Best Buy Gold, thanks to its fine dot pitch of 0.25 mm and a terrific video bandwidth of 200 MHz. This monitor made its mark felt in many tests. This was the only monitor which could do 1,600 x 1,200 at 75 Hz—a resolution and refresh rate usually found only on 19-inch models. It also had easy OSD functions, returned good results in the pincushion and barrel distortion tests, and showed no line moiré.

The ViewSonic E71f is our Silver winner. In fact, we also used it as our reference monitor. The ViewSonic E71f performed well and has a good feature set. The monitor came in a dual-tone black and silver grey finish, making it an attractive companion for those with black cabinets. The price of the monitor, however, is a little steep, and this was compounded by lower features scores—and it lost the top spot.

In the 19-inch category, the NEC FP912SB returned a commendable overall performance and the highest features scores, but because of its high price, it couldn't make it to the top. The HCL HCM985RFM is the cheapest 19-inch monitor available, and also performed impressively—making it desirable for budget buyers.

In the end, the day belonged to the Samsung siblings: the SyncMaster 997DF claimed Best Buy Gold because of its stable all-round performance. It managed decent results in difficult tests such as the screen regulation and the pincushion and barrel distortion test. The monitor did not display any ghosting or streaking, making it a good choice for graphics professionals, gamers, and those who want to migrate to a bigger screen.

The Samsung 957MB is our Best Buy Silver winner, as it had all the qualities of its sibling in terms of features and performance. The higher price tag of Rs 16,500, against Rs 14,900 for the SyncMaster 997DF, was the sole reason it won silver and not gold. The 957MB also deserves special mention, as it comes with the Magic Bright button, which is a factory-set brightness and contrast settings button optimised for different viewing conditions. ■

jayesh_limaye@thinkdigit.com
sanket_naik@thinkdigit.com

Contact Sheet

CRT Monitors

Brand	Company	Telephone	E-mail	Web site
Acer	Acer India Pvt Ltd	080-5219520-23	Rajesh.Aiyar@acer.co.in	www.acer.co.in
Benq	Benq India Pvt Ltd	022-25705230	SalesEnquiryIn@BenQ.com	www.benq.co.in
HCL	HCL Peripherals	044-5200 6570	kiruba@hclp.com	www.hclperipherals.com
LG	LG Electronics India Pvt Ltd	012-2560900-40	avarshney@lgezbuy.com	www.lgezbuy.com
Microtek	Microtek International Ltd	022-28362407	an.bom@mtk.sril.in	www.microtek.com.sg
NEC	Shiba Comp Pvt Ltd	011-26413437	sales@shibacomp.com	www.nec-mitsubishi.com
Philips	Philips India Ltd	022-56912324	pcp.india.info@philips.com	www.india.philips.com
Samsung	Samsung Electronics India	011-51511234	marketing@samsungindia.com	www.samsungindia.com
Viewsonic	Roop Technology Pvt Ltd	022-26680022	roop@vsnl.com	www.viewsonic.com